

The Church on the Hill

I

I had never much liked small-town life. Always confined to the same little city that sat at the saddle point of the valley. Each house was built to withstand the harsh winter conditions, and the people even more so. All the town's activity happened on the same old street, and all the rest were confined to people who had to frequent them. Even my own house, I didn't really like. It had that classic wide facade, with a low-angled roof that came off a little too far off the edge than I would have liked. The windows always froze in the winter, and the heater decided its hiatus ran from November to February.

Besides these annoying features, at the end of the day, it was my home, and I liked it as best I could. It kept me cozy and helped me get past hard times. The little corner where I would go whenever my anxiety spiked, and the couch that held so many tears of mine. Especially the dining table, which never hosted many guests except Lane.

She was my closest friend and a great person to snap you out of a tricky situation. She liked to wear really bright clothing, so that nobody would ever miss her as she walked down the street. Her hair equally displayed craziness. Always looking like she just woke up, yet she assured me she spent the better part of an hour styling it every morning. Besides her quirky characteristics, I loved her. She was an absolute gift, especially for me. She might not look it on the outside, but she is a composed and unflashy person inside, always curious and empathetic. I saw her almost every day except Sundays when she went up to that horrid church just outside of town.

Sitting atop a hill that overlooked the town. A small building dating back at least a few hundred years. Its simple architecture and design did everything but seem imposing, yet to me it still seemed imposing. Be day or night, it stared down upon the town. Shunning those who did not partake in its service. The wood had clearly been replaced at least twice, and a simple white cross stood atop its low-angle roof. How I hate those roofs. There were a few windows that looked out towards the parking lot and one that looked over the whole valley.

Lane didn't have a car, so I took her to mass every Sunday, save days when I had weekend classes. On those days, she would walk the two miles. Every time I would arrive a few minutes early and wait for her outside, reading my book, lost in the fantasies of Tolkien or Ishiguro. I would watch as people began trickling out one by one, like children getting dismissed from class. Lane would always be one of the last ones out, which made me a little irate.

She would walk out with a large smile on her face as if it were her birthday. Even on the day Jannet broke up with her, she entered with a gloom no one, not even me, could cure. An hour later, she came running out like a child who had just seen snow for the first time.

"Auden, you won't believe what Father Matthew told me," she said.

"What was it?" I replied, with no genuine interest in finding out.

"If I come for a few more sessions, he will send me on an expedition."

"That sounds great!" I feigned. "Where to?"

"He doesn't tell us till it's time. Koocham Falls or Plaxem Gorge, I hope. I've always wanted to visit.

The church had a strange tradition of sending the best members of the congregation * out on things they called expeditions. I didn't know much about them, but I had a few friends in common who had. I met them through Lane.

They were sent to select locations in the middle of nowhere. What they were tasked with, they can't say. They would stay in prebuilt wooden shacks that housed one. Some places required two, but most were just one. They stayed for 6 months, during which they (according to what they told me) would scan the premises and protect something they had down in the cellar. They were never allowed to go down, but they didn't mind. Their determination was set. I never really believed all this; I thought it was more of a wilderness boot camp.

"When would you leave?" I asked Lane.

"Father Matthew says once the snow thaws."

I wasn't too excited to hear this. "Could you delay it? Maybe till after I'm done with my initiation?"

"Little Auden scared to be all alone with her mom?"

"Piss off." I retorted, covering up the fact that she was dead right.

"Could I join you?" I asked. "I mean, I know that I have to be part of the church, but what if I joined. How long would it take?"

"OMG! Auden, yes, girl join!"

Lane was over the moon upon hearing my proposition. I wasn't sure why I said this. I was less than half a year from completing my initiation and getting my own patient. I was afraid to spend my remaining time before going off to Mount Roshak without Lane.

"I could ask Father Matthew. I'm sure it would take you a few weeks max. You are so well-behaved and an excellent learner. Let me go in and ask," She said as she darted towards the building.

"WAIT LANE!" I said, but it was too late.

The door shut with a loud thud. All of a sudden, the reality of my situation hit me. What the fuck had I just done? I was gonna get indoctrinated into that cult of a church. But I couldn't stand to tell Lane I was just joking. The total look of disappointment on her face would kill me. So I turned the car on and drove off without looking back. At that moment, I saw Lane come out of the door.

Upon getting home, I dreaded checking my phone. Lane would have left at least three different voicemails - as she often does. I did owe it to her, though. She had gone through the effort of asking and put herself on the line for me. I entered my hot and humid house, finding the place just as I had left it that morning. It was clean and organized, as I liked to keep it, except for the mess Kiwi always made with his plate. The bookshelf was arranged by color and content, and the couch cushions were placed as if she were expecting to show her house off to homebuyers.

Sure enough, I opened my phone and found three voicemails, each around 10 seconds long. Usually, the last one was the most desperate and contained all the information of the previous ones, so I played it.

"Hey Auden, I know it sounds a bit scary to join, especially knowing how much you don't like this place. But Father Matthew says you're more than welcome to join anytime, even after your initiation." There's a pause in the audio. "Anyways, are we still on for tonight? 6:30 at the Xing Fung Palace? Well, text me, call me, or whatever method of communication you want. Love you. Chao".

The message ended in a tone that I left droning on for a little longer than I wanted, lost in thought. I was terrified to show my face to her. She most likely held no grudge, as she often did, but I felt terrible.

In the end, I decided Lane deserved at least a reply; she was only trying to help out. I called her a few minutes later to let her know we were on for dinner. I arrived at around 6:20, and James sat me down. There aren't many restaurants, and you start to acquaint yourself with the people who work at those places really quickly.

"Are you waiting for Lane?" he asked me.

"Yeah. She should be here in 10 to 15 minutes."

"No problem. Do you want the usual to start?"

"That'd be great. Thanks, James."

James left immediately to fetch my drink, and I sat down at a booth next to a large window. I usually liked to arrive early if I could; I hated the idea of coming in and having to greet everyone that was already there. I much preferred it when they greeted me. Made it less of a social effort.

Right at 6:30, Lane arrived. I can't say I wasn't surprised. This was the most on time she had been in the past few months. I got up and gave her a huge hug.

"Auden!" She said so with such delight.

"Sorry about today, I just got a little overwhelmed with it all."

"Girl, you are so good. I know it's a lot, me leaving an' all."

We sat down, and Lane gave James a glance, nodding. "*The usual, please.*" James was on it.

I was worried about seeing her again after my quick departure. Still, her warm being always had a way of winning me over and calming my senses.

"How are you feeling about the transplant?" She asked me.

"I dunno, I'm ready, but it feels weird." I paused, even though I was rather good at the procedure and, after many practice sessions, I had never once flinched; the thought of it unsettled me. "I wish I could be a Keeper. Then I wouldn't have to deal with all this stuff."

"What are you talking about? Being an Overseer is so cool."

"You don't even know what an Overseer does."

"It has a cool name though."

I didn't respond, hoping a witty response would come.

"How about your expedition?" I said, trying to change the topic.

"Nice defelection, Auden."

"I didn't." She cut me off before I could say more.

"I think I'm ready. I'm gonna go out next week to the canyon. I feel that if I can survive the mental struggle for a few days, the rest will become habit after a while."

"You don't think that's dangerous?"

"Not really. I mean, if it goes bad, then I'll sure as hell know that I'm not ready for an expedition."

I looked at her with a bit of sadness. Why did she have to go? I wanted to beg her to stay, but I knew it would be in vain.

"Everyone who comes back is always altered and seems to have lost some spark they used to have," I said, hoping I could chisel away at her resolve.

"I'm not everyone," she said. "And besides, Mother Janett told me they wouldn't send me to a grueling one, they would keep it more on the mellow side, as I haven't been with them for a long time."

"But some don't even come back," I said. "We don't know why, and nobody has ever recovered."

"I'll be back. Do not worry. Your girl's strong," she said as she flexed her bicep.

She was indeed very muscular and had a regular workout routine to stay fit. Who knows why, but she looked terrific. I sometimes envied her physique, but was I really about to spend hours of my life in a box like a hamster? You bet your ass not.

James walked over with two drinks in hand and placed them on the table in front of us.

"One Savage Fruit Blend for you," he said, looking at me, "and a Pornstar Martini for you," he said, giving Lane a flirtatious look.

James had tried for a couple of months to get with Lane to no avail. Guess the trail went cold on his previous pursuit.

Lane was bisexual but said she preferred the temperament of some women to that of men, but the *go-do-it* attitude of most men.

"Thank you, Jamie," she told him in a reciprocal flirt.

She did this every time, and I had no clue why. It felt rather cruel to carry him along.

"Thanks, James," I said. "Ohh! Can you tell your dad my mom has some pastries for him?"

"I will"

"Thanks," I said. James walked away, and the two of us immediately started slurping up our drinks.

We talked for a long time about many things, and Lane made me smile like a crazy maniac. The whole time, I resented my inability to discourage Lane from leaving. We laughed a great deal, and by the end of the dinner, I was drunk. She had to drive me home. We lived only a few blocks away, but decided to sleep over that night to make sure I didn't choke to death. It was

a terrible idea to get drunk that night. The day after was my first transplant demonstration, and I should have been of a clear mind. Still, I couldn't contain myself, especially around Lane.

The next morning, I walked into the auditorium where my demonstration was being held. I was surprised to see I wasn't at all hungover. I guess the nerves I had during breakfast shook all that out of my system real quick. Nevertheless, I had my nerves under control, and I was ready for the transplant. The auditorium seated around 100 people, with the chairs arranged in three groups that ran down to a semicircle stage at the bottom. The stage was made of shiny, polished wooden planks, and a large white display screen hung behind it. Atop the stage lay a large table with a freshly cleaned white cloth. Beside it was a small rollable metal table with tools neatly arranged. I walked down to the stage and sat in the chair on the side so the advisors could watch their students' work.

I closed my eyes and began to unfold my procedure in my mind. I liked to do this to get the idea of what I had to do out of my head, and when I was up there, all I would do was act and move, no thinking. I took deep breaths and placed my hands palm up on my thighs.

One of the auditorium doors opened, and a man wearing a stout fedora and a caramel scarf walked in. He wore a nice dark blue three-piece suit and a small orchid in his breast pocket. His well-dressed attire made me worry whether I was underdressed. I was wearing a thin wool sweater with a button-down underneath whose collar stuck out above it, my high-waisted pants that almost touched the floor and were a little too big, so I always had to wear a belt with them, and my favorite dark red ballet flats. I quickly let go of my anxiety. Professor Morrison was always one to overdress, so I was most likely well dressed. He walked over to me and gave me a big hug.

"Seeing the future are we?" He asked me.

"Yep," I responded with zeal.

"You ready for this, kiddo?" He said.

I nodded.

"Go show these society members your talent," he said.

I smiled at him and stuck out my hand. He reciprocated with a stern handshake and patted my shoulder with his other hand.

"Go get show 'em what you got," he said.

Then we both stood there for a moment, like a Mexican standoff. I wasn't sure what he wanted. He gestured towards the chair.

"Ohh, yeah. Sorry," I said as I walked over to seat myself on one of the front row seats.

It wasn't long before people started pouring in. First came the Ministry members, eight in total, all looking almost identical in their black suits with light-pink button-ups, whose collars never poked out from their jackets. They were always the first to be let in. Every single person who came from the Ministry looked almost like a combination of both genders, totally androgynous.

A minute later, the spectators arrived, people from the institution who came for learning purposes. Nobody outside the institution was allowed to see or even know about the procedure. It was all kept in shadow.

Everyone sat down, and Number 3 (the ministry people were always numbered; none of us knew their names) gestured for the lab assistant to wheel out the subject. The small, scruffy boy in white hospital scrubs, who had arrived shortly after the Ministry members and stood at the side of the stage, walked through a door to the side. He wheeled out a table with a middle-aged woman. Behind came another assistant dressed similarly, wheeling a teenage girl who looked about 18 or 19. The woman was placed to the side of the table, draped with the tablecloth, and the girl was picked up and placed on the table. Number 7 raised a hand, permitting me to go up on stage. They then read off notes from a paper in front of them.

"Carcass – Lillian Wharton. Age 39. Height 5'9". Physical Condition: Semi-healthy. Has an on-and-off case of asthma, and the lungs are damaged due to 14 years of chronic smoking. Mental Condition: Healthy, save sparse manic episodes and feelings of paranoia." Number 7 stopped to take another sheet that Number 6 was handing to them.

"Patient – Evelyn Drevmont. Age 19. Height: 5'5". Physical Condition: Healthy, except for an unpredictable menstrual cycle. Mental condition: Brain dead." Number 7 looked up at me.

"Auden Rainer, you may now proceed as needed." I looked out into the auditorium that was almost half full. I was glad my demonstration wasn't too popular; fewer eyes stared me down. I began my operation on the middle-aged woman. I grabbed a black marker and drew a black line along the upper forehead. I then swirled around to grab the scalpel.

II

It was three days later, when I was driving to the St. Jane Recovery Center, that a rush of emotions from that day came to me. I have a habit of not clearly remembering events that are high in concentration or stress. All I always seem to recall is how I felt. While driving, the memory of an absolute sense of relief that ensnared me when I opened the middle-aged woman's skull and managed not to kill the brain was awesome, as well as the feeling of overwhelming excitement when I replaced the young woman's brain with that of the middle-aged one and the young woman's flexors started twitching.

I had practiced the operation procedure many times and conducted it on other animals, especially primates. This was my first time doing this operation on humans. In fact, I was the third person to successfully reproduce it after Dr. Gulliver discovered the method. Professor Morrison, of course, being the first person to reproduce it, as well as improving the technique, keeps the brain from totally decaying and losing blood before placing it in its new body. There was usually a loss of neurons, and sometimes only insignificant motor functions. The patients typically take a while to remember their names and other basic things.

I arrived at St. Jane's, and the warm morning sun caressed my face through the car windows. I parked in the small lot off to the right, where all the employees had their cars. There

seemed to be a trend I clearly was not in on: buying white Toyota Priuses and adding a heart to your license plate. I found it quite strange, but the people here operate more like a family than coworkers. I got out of the car and felt my phone ring. I excitedly took it out, hoping to see a message from Lane. Nothing but a lousy spam email I should have unsubscribed from, but keep forgetting to.

Lane was leaving in a few days and had asked me to help her pack, but I had completely ignored her. I was living in denial about her departure and hoped that if I didn't think about it, it wouldn't happen. That morning, I had finally mustered the courage to let her know I would help out that afternoon. Right now, though, I had no time to worry about that, so I walked up the stairs into the main hall of the building. A few nurses at the entrance greeted me with smiles and nods, and Eliot (my favorite nurse) came up to me, gave me a hug, and walked alongside me.

"Hey sis," he said.

I never really liked being called that, but everybody here did it. It was strange.

"Hey Eliot," I said. "How's Evelyn?"

"Good, good. She's recovering rather quickly. She's just started large-muscle movements. Her legs are active, and her arms are basically back. She does say she feels something odd with her breasts and legs. Saying they feel smaller than she remembers.

"She's probably still recovering from the coma."

"Makes sense... I guess," he said. He suddenly turned around to look at me. "She keeps saying her name is Lillian. Seems quite strange. Doesn't feel like the type of thing that gets misunderstood."

Evelyn was admitted on the pretence that she was in a coma and had just woken up two days ago. She was scheduled to be transferred on Friday morning, two days from now. She was being sent to Gallen Marlow Correctional Facility – it sounds a lot worse than it is... at least for my type of patient.

We arrived at a door labeled 237. Eliot left me at the door, not stopping his walk and waving as he got farther away. I took my long oval glasses off and walked inside. The room looked sterile and clean (of course it was) with two walls having a hexagonal tiling pattern of browns, pinks and yellows. The room had two windows in the back of the room which were placed high up. A few special rooms were constructed to eliminate all reflective materials save the medical instruments that were sometimes used. The raised windows insure natural light but no accessible reflections. The patients were devoid of seeing themselves in the first week after the procedure. There needed to be a more concrete idea of self rebuilt before they could get any such confirmation that they were indeed external. Evelyn lay sitting up on the bed, watching her hand as she twirled her wrist, then extended and loosened her forearm muscles. She didn't notice me walk in.

"Hey Lilli, how are you doing?" I asked as I pulled a chair up next to her bed. She turned around in a small fright. I told her with a smile and gentle tone, "Just me, no blood samples needed today." Her face relaxed, and she gave me a hint of a smile. "I can see your limbs are moving more freely now."

“It feels... I don't know.” She struggled to find the right words. “Like a deflated balloon. Everything is still there, but things don't feel normal. My arms move with more ease, and my breasts feel stiffer. It feels really nice to breathe.” She poked one of her breasts and waved her as if waving the checkered flag at car races.

“You need time to recover. Memories take time to come back, feelings and sensations are a lot more immediate,” I told her.

“Ohh! Jamie! That name keeps coming to me. It feels so natural to say, but I don't remember anyone named Jamie. Like a memory just out of reach,” she said as she stared into the oblivion, trying hard to recall.

“I'm sure it will come to you in a few days,” I said, wanting to move on to what I actually came here for. “How are you feeling about moving?”

“I think I'm ready. I was walking with Ms. Nance yesterday, and it felt real good. Maybe one more day of aided walking and I think I'm ready to do it all by myself.”

“That's great to hear! Do you prefer hard or soft pillows?”

“Soft, I guess...” she held up one of the pillows on her bed. “This one feels real good.”

I merely just asked the question out of courtesy. Most of the physical preferences came from Evelyn – well... her body. At the end of the procedure, Number 2 gave me a file containing all the information I needed about Evelyn. Fewer physical *likes* and dislikes came from Lilli; whether she liked pale yellow or rich neon green was up to her brain, not her body. Dr. Gulliver had noticed a discontinuity between a person's “mental” *likes* and how a certain *like* made them feel. His second patient loved lilac flowers, but when some were brought to his room, his body reacted with repulsion to them, even though he had wanted them so badly a few hours ago. I still don't know what that's about – could be an outlier.

“Is there anything you want for the room?” I asked.

“Could I get a typewriter?”

Quite the strange request, I thought. Not sure how many of those were still available and in good condition. I nodded.

“I can try,” I said.

“I like to feel my words and not see them on a glowing plane.”

I spent some more time asking her preference questions. For patients like these, we have attempted to make their spaces a little less prison-like and more inviting. Making it feel cozy to live in. This would help mitigate the effects of external factors on our observations and analysis.

I was the head Overseer on her case (the chief operator usually is) and had planned for her to stay in the facility for about three weeks. It lasted longer than the usual 1 week, except for the heart patients, who spent 2 weeks, although the heart seemed to cause significant differences between the recipient and the host*. I wanted to be damn sure she felt comfortable and safe. This was my first patient, so I didn't want them bashing their head to death.

“If you need anything, you can always call for a nurse. If you need me, you can have them phone me.” I told her.

“Thanks”

I got up and started walking towards the door, not noticing my glasses, which I had in my pocket, had fallen out and lay on the chair. I went to grab them and found them nowhere to be found. I turned around to see Evelyn reaching for them.

“No, no, don't grab them!” I said, trying to sound as calm as possible.

Evelyn immediately stopped, a little surprised by the sudden outburst. I went over and grabbed the glasses.

“Excuse me,” I said, holding them close to my chest. “They were my grandmas.”

Evelyn suddenly lost interest in me. I had just taken a new toy away from a child. I dismissed it and walked out of the room. So far, she was doing very well; I was glad.

I reached my car and put all my stuff in the trunk. My phone began to ring, I looked down. It was Lane! Thank god she called. I picked up.

“Hey!” I said.

“The dead have risen.”

“Yeah, sorry about that, I've just been really busy.”

“No problem. I know you're allergic to phone calls.” She said with a chortle. “I wanted to know whether you have an extra raincoat? I have one, but I want to make sure I have an extra in case. It would be a miserable time if my only one were ripped or somehow damaged.”

“I think I might. I'll go to my house and check before coming over.”

“OMG! Thanks. I'm so excited to see you! What time are you planning on coming?”

I dropped the phone from my ear before she could finish. There was a figure in my periphery approaching me. I turned around to look at them. It was a shorter man who wore black pants and a button-up shirt with a Roman collar. His small circular glasses glinted at me, obscuring his eyes. He introduced himself as Father Matthew in a sweet, warm tone.

“Ms. Rainer. Am I correct?” He said. “Lane's told me all about you”

I told him to give me a moment, holding out a finger. I put the phone to my ear.

“Hey Lane, I'll call you back.”

“Okie dokie,” Lane responded with glee.

I hung up the call and turned around to Father Matthew.

“Sorry about that,” I told him.

“No worries,” he said, waving his hand as if waving away my apology. “I came to check up on Evelyn and see how she's doing.”

“She's doing fine, doing a lot better than a few days ago. The fall did a number on her.”

“I'm sorry to hear that. She was an excellent member of our community.” He said as he faced me, but his eyes seemed to focus behind me. “Also, if you still want to join, you're always welcome to. Our doors are open to anyone, and we love having new people. You could come for a day and see how you like it.”

“If I have the time, I'll be sure to stop by,” I said, trying to get out of the situation. “I have to head out now, Lane's expecting me, but it was nice to meet you.”

I waved at him and got in my car. I didn't look back to see his response.

As I pulled away he stood there looking at me with a faint smile, waving goodbye. I wasn't sure why he was here. He would surely be turned away from seeing Evelyn. Nobody but the nurses and some select institution members were allowed to see her so early in her recovery.

III

I hadn't made it to Lane's that afternoon. As soon as I got into her neighborhood, I got a call from the hospital saying that Evelyn was acting up and having a serious panic attack, and calling my name over and over again. I turned around and rushed over, completely forgetting to let Lane know I wouldn't make it. I'm such a bad friend. I can't even communicate with her, and I leave her in such high spirits just to never arrive. This wasn't the first time I'd done this.

It was Friday, and Evelyn had calmed down, but she was less active than before. Eliot had told me she started acting this way when a pastor came to see her. I asked him why he was let in; as far as I knew, he wasn't on the list. Eliot said he was, he had full clearance to see her and offer anything she needed. Why, why! Why did he have to ruin this? The drive to the hospital was an excruciatingly nerve-racking one. I couldn't have my first patient dying only days after the operation. I had taken all precautions as instructed.

Lane had forgiven me for not arriving (I love her so much), and we were going to spend some time together that afternoon before she left at dusk. I was hoping to get more time with her, but I had brought this on myself. I was sitting stretched out on my couch, Kiwi lying at my feet. He suddenly jolted up, looking at the door. He always knew when she was coming before I did. I heard a series of silent knocks on the door.

I got up and opened the door. Lane launched herself upon me, her bright orange and yellow shirt looking like a wave of colored water rushing over me. She gave a huge hug, squeezing tightly.

"Can't escape now. You're trapped," she chuckled.

"Are you hungry? I have some leftover pasta and spinach, or I can make you some burgers."

"Let's do burgers."

I walked over to the kitchen, and Lane stayed back to play with Kiwi for a while. Kiwi loved her. She always knew his favorite rub spots.

I began preparing the food. It didn't take me that long, after all, I just have to cook patties, slap cheese on top, and toast the buns. Easiest meal ever (at least to cook). Lane came into the kitchen, Kiwi following closely behind.

"